Philosophy · Epistemology · AQA A-level (7172)

Infallibilism

A workbook to use alongside the lesson slides: consolidate the theory, then practise the exam questions.

Name ..... Date .....

Infallibilism is one response to the Gettier problem. It keeps the tripartite definition of knowledge (justified true belief) but asks much more of justification. This workbook takes you through the theory one step at a time. Each part matches a section of the slides, so you can pick it up even if you missed a lesson.

In this handout

1. What infallibilism claims
2. Two kinds of certainty
3. Infallibilism and the Gettier problem
4. Two problems for infallibilism
5. Exam questions (3, 5, 5 and 12 marks)

Part 01 What infallibilism claims

Use with slides 2, 3 and 8.

> **Key Thesis**
> To be knowledge, a belief must be certain. If we can doubt a belief, then it is not certain, and so it is not knowledge. We could put it like this: to know, you must know that you know.

Infallibilism is about justification. The tripartite view says that a belief needs justification to count as knowledge, but it does not say how much justification is enough. Infallibilism answers: justification requires certainty.

So, for the infallibilist, to know P it must be impossible to doubt P:

1. P must be true.
2. P is believed because it is impossible to doubt.
3. P is justified because of 2.

Exercise 1 Fill the gaps

Use each word from the word bank once.

Infallibilism is a theory of ..... It says that a belief is only knowledge if its justification ..... that the belief is true. So knowledge requires .....: if it is possible to ..... P, then you do not know P. Infallibilism keeps the ..... definition of knowledge, but makes the justification condition much .....

Word bank certainty · doubt · guarantees · justification · stricter · tripartite

Part 02 Two kinds of certainty

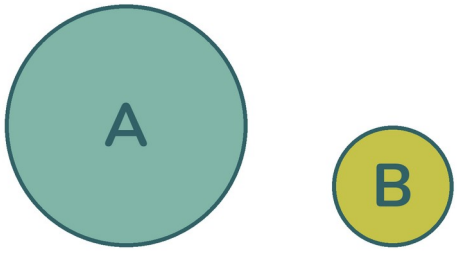
Use with slides 4, 5 and 6.

The word 'certainty' can work in two different ways. Infallibilism only works if we keep them apart.

	(1) Feeling certain	(2) Impossible to doubt
What is it about?	*The believer: a psychological, subjective feeling of confidence.*	*The belief itself: when you consider it, the belief confirms itself.*
Can it be wrong?	*Yes. You can feel certain and still be mistaken.*	*No. It cannot be false while you are considering it.*
Example from the slides	*Someone feels certain that the earth is flat. It is still round.*	*Descartes' cogito: doubting that I am thinking is itself thinking.*
Is it justification?	*No. A feeling does not make a belief true.*	*Yes. Only this kind could meet the infallibilist standard.*

A truth you can see at once

Look at the two circles, then read the proposition underneath.



Proposition: **A is larger than B.**

Self-evident A truth is self-evident when you can see that it is true just by considering it. You do not need a further argument.

Exercise 2 Test the proposition

a) Did you need an argument, or any extra evidence, to accept that A is larger than B? Explain.

b) Now try to deny it. Look at the circles and say 'A is not larger than B'. What happens?

c) Think further: you know this by looking. Could your eyes ever mislead you? Would an infallibilist accept that you know it?

The denial test

Here is a way to tell the two kinds of certainty apart. Take the proposition and try to deny it.

1. If the denial contradicts itself, or defeats itself, the proposition is impossible to doubt. This is certainty in sense (2).
2. If the denial makes sense, even though you are very sure it is wrong, then you only feel certain. This is certainty in sense (1).

Example of (2): 'A triangle has three sides.' The denial, 'a triangle does not have three sides', contradicts what 'triangle' means. In the cogito, the denial defeats itself: to deny that I am thinking, I have to think.

Example of (1): 'My team will win on Saturday.' You may feel completely sure. But the denial, 'my team will not win', contains no contradiction. It could turn out either way.

Exercise 3 Feeling certain, or impossible to deny?

The first two rows are done for you. Complete the rest, then add two examples of your own.

Proposition	Write its denial	Does the denial contradict (or defeat) itself?	Feeling certain, or impossible to deny?
A triangle has three sides.	*A triangle does not have three sides.*	*Yes. 'Triangle' means a three-sided shape.*	*Impossible to deny*
My team will win on Saturday.	*My team will not win on Saturday.*	*No. It could turn out either way.*	*Feeling certain*
I am thinking.			
The earth is flat.			
2 + 3 = 5			
It will rain tomorrow.			
All bachelors are unmarried.			
I locked the front door this morning.			
A is larger than B. (the circles)			
My own example:			
My own example:			

Part 03 Infallibilism and the Gettier problem

Use with slides 6, 7 and 15.

Why think justification has to be this strict? The slides set out the reasoning in steps:

1. No one can know what is false.
2. So, if I know P, I cannot be mistaken about P.
3. Therefore, justification must guarantee truth.
4. If I am justified in believing that P, I cannot possibly be mistaken.
5. Therefore, if it is possible that I am mistaken, I am not justified in believing that P.

Applying it to Gettier's job case

Smith has strong evidence that Jones will get the job and that Jones has 10 coins in his pocket. So Smith infers: 'The man who will get the job has 10 coins in his pocket.' In fact Smith gets the job, and Smith also happens to have 10 coins.

On the tripartite view, Smith's belief is true, believed and justified, yet it is true by luck. That is the Gettier problem. The infallibilist replies that Smith was never justified in the first place: his evidence could be doubted, and it led him to a falsehood (that Jones would get the job).

Exercise 4 Two verdicts on Smith's belief

For each condition write Yes or No, and a short reason.

Smith's belief: 'The man who will get the job has 10 coins in his pocket'	Tripartite view says…	Infallibilism says…
Is it true?		
Does Smith believe it?		
Is Smith justified?		
So does Smith know it?		

a) Why can a belief whose justification guarantees its truth never be true by luck?

Part 04 Two problems for infallibilism

Use with slide 9.

The slides raise two problems:

1. If infallibilism is true, then we have very little knowledge. The level of justification we would need is too high.

2. Might infallibility be a vice rather than a virtue, because it stops us having a broader definition of knowledge?

Exercise 5 What survives?

Write three things you would normally say you know. Then test each one.

Something I would normally say I know	Is it possible to doubt it? How?	Knowledge for the infallibilist?
1.		
2.		
3.		

a) What does your table show about how much knowledge infallibilism allows?

Check your understanding

Tick one box for each statement. Be honest: this tells you what to revisit on the slides.

I can…	Not yet	Nearly	Secure
define infallibilism precisely (slides 2, 3, 8, 12)			
explain the difference between feeling certain and a belief that is impossible to doubt (slides 4 to 6, 13)			
explain how infallibilism responds to Gettier's job case (slides 7, 15)			
explain the two problems for infallibilism (slide 9)			

Part 05 Exam questions

Use with slides 11 to 15. Plan first, then write. Aim for precise terms and clear steps.

Question 1 What is infallibilism? (3 marks)

Aim: a precise definition in two or three sentences. No examples needed.

Question 2 Explain the difference between feeling certain about a belief and being certain because you have entertained the belief. (5 marks)

Plan: define each kind, give one example of each, then state the difference.

Question 3 **Explain the difference between the claim 'You cannot know what is false' and the claim 'When you know, you could not possibly have been wrong'.**
(5 marks)

Plan: explain claim 1, explain claim 2, give an example that separates them, conclude.

Plan for Question 4

Six steps, one line each: tripartite view, Gettier's case, the problem, the diagnosis, the infallibilist response, conclusion.

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

6.

Question 4 **Outline and explain how infallibilism tries to solve the Gettier problem. (12 marks)**

No evaluation needed: marks come from precise terms and each step following from the last.